THAT FOG IN THE GREY CELLS



From impaired cognitive functions and mood disorders to neurological damage, the coronavirus's impact on brain health cannot be taken lightly

By **Sonali Acharjee** / *Illustration by* **NILANJAN DAS**

A Covid-negative report after a bout of the infection might seem like a moment to celebrate, but for many, it's just the beginning of another ordeal. Two months after Aabha Malik tested negative, her life and work continue to be affected. "I put my pen down and two minutes later forget where I kept it. When others are speaking, I find it difficult to focus on the words. It feels like my brain is stuck," says the 28-year-old IT research intern in Bengaluru. While her colleagues jokingly call her "noodle brain", her doctor says she is suffering from mental fogginess—a condition often associated with cancer patients undertaking chemotherapy (commonly called chemobrain), where key cognitive functions such as attention and memory, besides emotions and sleep, get impacted.

"When the pandemic began," says Dr M.V. Padma Srivastava, head of neurology and chief of the neurosciences centre at AIIMS, Delhi, "we assumed the symptoms would be primarily in the lungs. But now it is quite clear that the virus can affect almost any organ, including the brain. In India, we have seen a number of patients with brain